

Global Markets Daily: Can Japanese Savings Boost JGBs?

- Recent comments by Japanese finance minister Katayama and Prime Minister Takaichi suggest policymakers are considering ways to increase domestic purchases of Japanese assets, with two potential measures that could support JGBs: adjusting GPIF's asset allocation towards domestic assets, and allowing JGBs to be included in the tax-free NISA savings vehicle.
- Under GPIF's current strategy, there is roughly USD75bn of room to increase allocation to JGBs. While not particularly large relative to ongoing rebalancing flows, which are themselves generated by higher yields, a weaker currency, and domestic equity outperformance, a pro-active reallocation would carry greater signalling value than these mechanical flows.
- We estimate that shifting the domestic bond share from 27% to 31% would be worth around 3-6bp in 30y swap spreads, comparable to the 8bp round trip seen this week, though the pace of portfolio adjustment is likely to be slow given the domestic bond share has only fluctuated by 1-2ppts per year.
- Allowing tax-advantaged ownership of JGBs through NISA could increase demand, but low household allocations are more likely a function of historically low yields than tax status; as in Italy, rising retail ownership is typically associated with rising, not falling, yields.
- Both measures have the potential to increase demand for JGBs, but the majority of the impact is likely to come through signalling and positive feedback loops rather than outright purchases. We see more room for 20s and 30s to outperform alongside wider 20y and 30y swap spreads, but a sustainable decline in JGB volatility ultimately requires shifts to fiscal and monetary policy rather than supply, as most of the cheapening in the curve has been macro-led.

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Can Japanese Savings Boost JGBs?

Recent comments by Japanese Finance Minister Katayama and Prime Minister Takaichi suggest policymakers in Japan are considering ways to increase domestic purchases of Japanese assets. JGBs rallied on the initial comments, with long-end JGBs outperforming in particular vs swaps. These moves have subsequently retraced, however, as the latest communication seemed to skew towards domestic equities rather than bonds.

In principle, the use of Japan's strong NIIP position could be used to bolster domestic

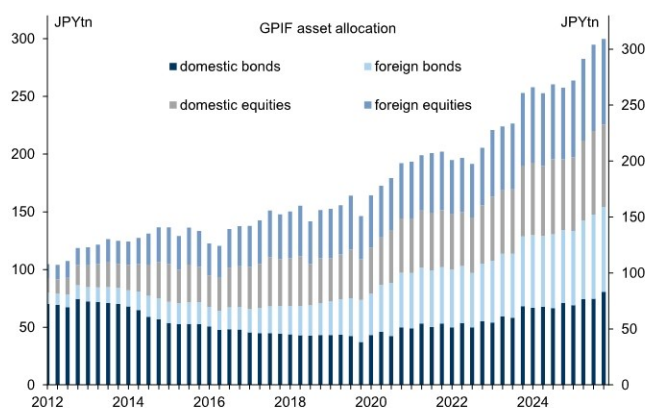
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assets and stabilise the currency, as domestic savings are redirected. As we will discuss below, this comes at some economic risk however, and without complementary macro shifts in policy and/or inflation, may not generate new equilibrium conditions for Japanese assets. Moreover, Japan already has among the lowest G10 foreign ownership shares of its government bonds, at around 14%, which leaves limited room for further domestic savings to be directed to JGBs. Nonetheless, two possibilities have been proposed to support domestic assets and JGBs: i) adjusting the asset allocation of the Government Pension Investment Fund (GPIF) towards domestic assets, and ii) allowing JGBs to be included in the Nippon Individual Savings Accounts (NISA), a tax-free savings vehicle offered to households. We investigate the potential implications of each.

GPIF

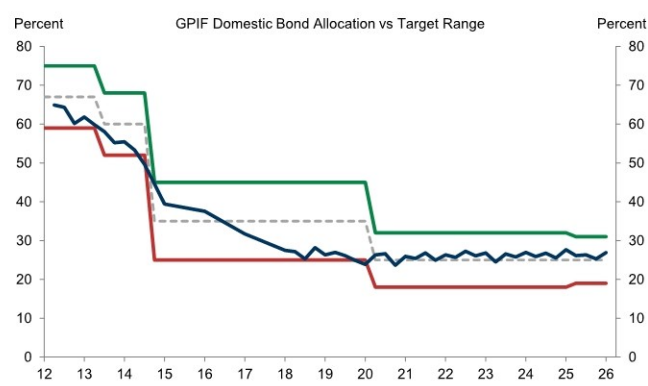
As of end-March 2026, GPIF manages around USD2.8tn in assets, allocated around a 25% benchmark for each of i) domestic bonds, ii) foreign bonds, iii) domestic equity and iv) foreign equity. Since 2014, GPIF holdings have gravitated away from domestic bonds to the roughly equal shares currently ([Exhibit 1](#) & [Exhibit 2](#)). Current ownership represents around 5% of the JGB market, and just under 1% of the UST, Bund and Gilt market, among other G10s.

Exhibit 1: GPIF holdings have gravitated away from domestic bonds



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Haver Analytics

Exhibit 2: GPIF's current strategy targets a 25% allocation to domestic bonds, within a +/-6% range that has narrowed over time

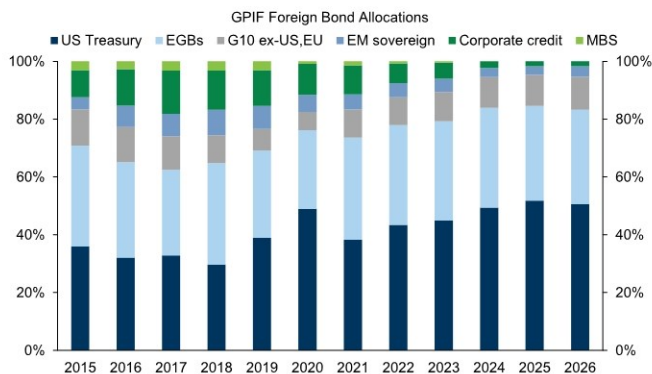


Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

From GPIF's annual data on individual bond holdings¹, we calculate JGBs typically represent around 80-90% of GPIF's domestic bond holdings, while USTs represent around 50% of foreign bonds ([Exhibit 3](#)). Since 2019 foreign bond holdings have moved further towards sovereign bonds and away from corporate credit, with USTs and EGBs over 80% of the total. The weighted average maturity of GPIF's sovereign holdings has been relatively steady, and close to or just above the overall stock in each market ([Exhibit 4](#)).

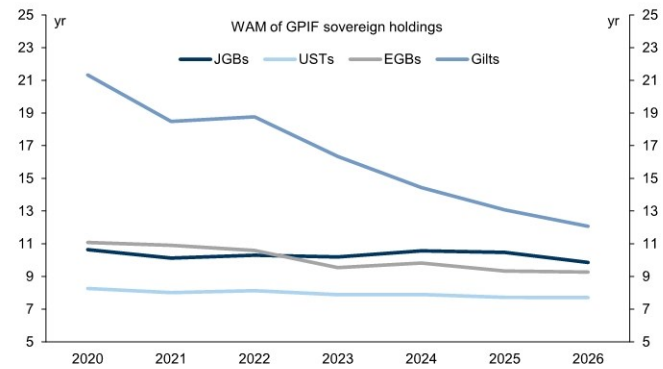
¹ GPIF publishes annual data on ISIN level holdings since 2019.

Exhibit 3: JGBs represent around 80-90% of domestic bond holdings, while USTs represent around 50% of foreign bond holdings



Source: GPIF, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

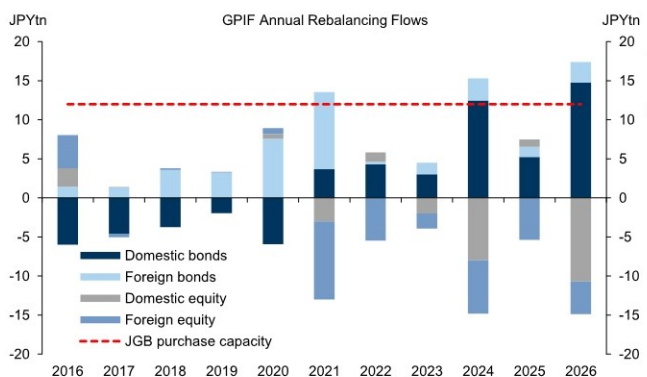
Exhibit 4: The WAM of GPIF's sovereign holdings has been relatively steady and close to the market, outside of Gilts



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Bloomberg

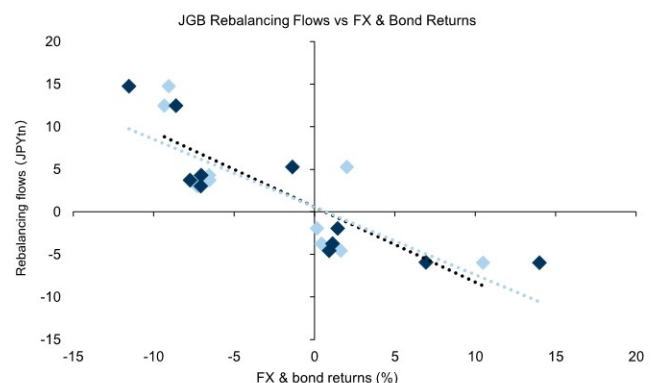
GPIF's current strategy (due for review in 2030) allows for flexibility around this 25% share—for domestic bonds, this is currently ± 6 pts, a share that has narrowed over time ([Exhibit 2](#)). Under the current strategy (also due for revision in 2030), there is roughly USD75bn of room to increase allocation to JGBs. But this is not particularly large in the context of GPIF's ongoing purchases in the market. Given strong investment returns from equity markets, and foreign assets in general, owing to a much weaker JPY in recent years, plus the underperformance of JGBs from higher yields, GPIF needs to re-balance its portfolio towards JGBs just to keep the share of domestic bonds stable over time ([Exhibit 5](#)). Recent rebalancing towards JGBs has actually been larger than the current capacity to expand JGB purchases. Of course, the ultimate market effect of a pro-active reallocation to JGBs would likely be more meaningful and have greater signalling value than rebalancing flows, which themselves are generated by higher yields and a weaker currency ([Exhibit 6](#)).

Exhibit 5: GPIF needs to re-balance its portfolio towards JGBs just to keep the share of domestic bonds stable over time



Source: Haver Analytics, GPIF, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6: Rebalancing flows are generated by higher yields and a weaker currency

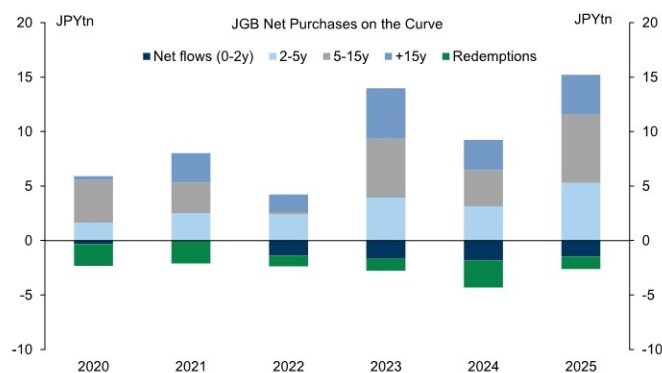


Source: Bloomberg, GPIF, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

One possibility for increased flows to JGBs to have a more meaningful impact is a redirection towards the long-end. GPIF already does this to some extent—given the WAM of holdings is relatively constant (outside of Gilts), this requires a constant rebalancing within each curve towards longer maturities. By stripping out valuation

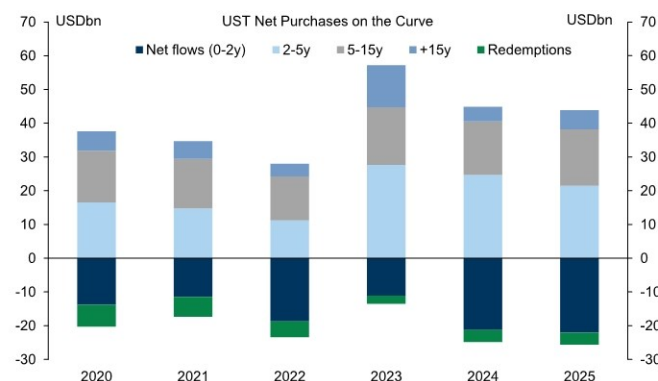
changes due to price (yield) and currency movements in the case of foreign bonds, we see that on net, GPIF manages each curve by selling its shorter maturity bonds (sub-2y) and purchasing longer maturities—[Exhibit 7](#) and [Exhibit 8](#) show this for both JGBs and USTs. This shows at least some capacity to direct flows towards long-end bonds, which is where we have [argued](#) there is probably the most ‘bang for the buck’ for the JPY curve.

Exhibit 7: GPIF manages WAM by selling its shorter maturity bonds (sub-2y) and purchasing longer maturities in JGBs...



Source: GPIF, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 8: ...and its foreign bond holdings

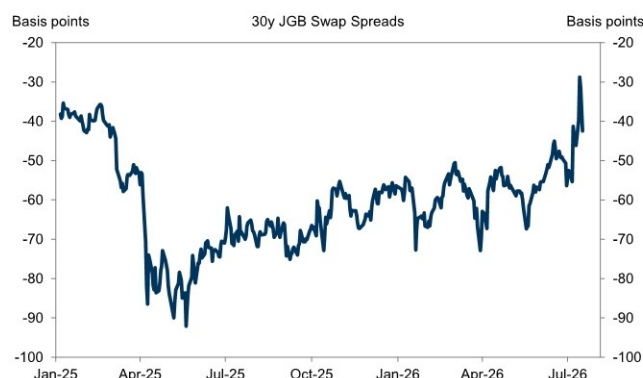


Source: GPIF, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Although the sensitivities of JGB swap spreads to debt supply have historically been a little lower than in other markets, the recent volatility in JGBs points to the potential for increased local sensitivity to supply shifts. For USTs, Bunds and Gilts, our swap spread frameworks estimate that a 1ppt change in “free float” (the share of debt owned by the private sector) is worth around 1bp on 30y swap spreads, but the impact could be larger (e.g. 2-4bp) if flows are disproportionately directed into 30y bonds or catalyses more ‘crowding in’ from other domestic buyers beyond any direct GPIF flows. Shifting from the current domestic bond share of 27% to 31% (the maximum under the current strategy, and around USD75bn in addition JGB purchases) would represent around 3-6bp in 30y spreads—this compares with an 8bp round trip in 30y swap spreads this week ([Exhibit 9](#)).

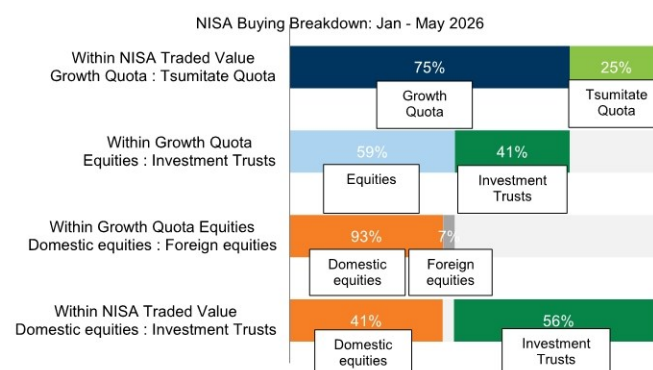
The volatile market reaction may reflect an extrapolation of potential GPIF reallocation to the broader pension industry. Of course, the size of the near-term reaction would also depend on the speed of adjustment but given the domestic bond share has only fluctuated by 1-2ppts per year, this shift is likely to be slow. And more meaningful shifts, such as the benchmark share allocated to domestic vs foreign assets, would likely need to wait several years. Less tangibly, the market may also be reacting positively to signs that the government is more attuned to risks in the bond market and searching for ways to address them. These measures are ultimately not a solution to the macro-led volatility in rates, but instead could function as a means to attenuate volatility from the current monetary and fiscal policy stance.

Exhibit 9: 30y swap spreads have moved by 8-10 basis points this week



Source: Goldman Sachs FICC and Equities, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 10: NISA's growth quota currently allows for investments in JGB funds, but not direct investment in JGBs



Source: JSDA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Given the relatively low ownership share of G10 bond markets (less than 1pp of the major bond markets), modest redirection of GPIF holdings away from foreign bonds to JGBs would have a small direct impact. Given the revealed behaviour to rebalancing by selling short maturity bonds, it is also not clear this would have a major curve impact. Of course, should it become a broader policy of domestic investors to divest or redirect away from foreign bonds, it could become more meaningful, but we do not consider this a key input for cross market or swap spreads.

NISA

The second measure that has been proposed is to make JGBs eligible in Nippon Individual Savings Accounts (NISA), a tax-free savings vehicle offered to households intended to support conversion of cash savings into long-term investments. Over 20mn accounts have been opened with over JPY71tn in traded value as of end-2025, indicating widespread usage. Within the “growth quota”, which makes up 75% of NISA traded value, investors are able to allocate purchases to a broad range of assets, including individual domestic and foreign equities, ETFs, REITs, and active mutual funds ([Exhibit 10](#)). NISA’s growth quota currently allows for investments in JGB funds, but not direct investment in JGBs. (The Tsumitate quota, in contrast, is restricted to low cost, diversified, equity mutual funds.) Direct ownership of JGBs across households is low, at about 4% of portfolio assets after stripping out NISA accounts.

Allowing for tax-advantaged ownership of JGBs could increase demand, but low allocations are likely a function of historically low yields than tax status. As we have [shown](#) in the case of Italy, increasing retail ownership is typically associated with rising, not falling, yields. The same is true of GPIF flows—as we described above, substantial rebalancing flows are a consequence of rising yields and JPY underperformance, rather than a driver of JGB outperformance. This suggests to us that while there may be modest swap spread effects from some redirection of domestic savings to JGBs, we think the route to lower yields and lower rate volatility is a macro one—some combination of tighter fiscal or monetary policy, and/or a downward shift in the inflation trajectory.

Both the GPIF and NISA measures have the potential to increase demand for JGBs, but

their impact is likely to come through signaling and positive feedback loops rather than outright purchases. And we see the impact on other bond markets as even more limited. Given more supply-related cheapening at the very long end, we think 20s and 30s have more room to richen, alongside 20y and 30y swap spreads. The macro-led cheapening in 10s and the belly are less likely to be supported, as evidenced by persistent 10s30s flattening. Ultimately, the bulk of the cheapening in the curve has been policy-related, meaning that a sustainable decline in JGB volatility has to come from shifts to fiscal and monetary policy rather than supply.

TRADE IDEAS



Best Trade Ideas Across Assets

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1. Stay short SGD/MYR, opened January 24, 2026, at 3.13, with a target at 2.90 and a stop at 3.30, currently trading at 3.17.
2. Stay long TRY, NGN and KZT against the USD, as an equally weighted basket, opened February 18, 2026, at 0%, with a total return target of 7.5%, and a revised stop of 1.5%, currently trading at 4.2%.
3. Stay long 3y SOFR swap spread, opened 17 April 2026, at -22.6bp, with a revised target at -15bp inclusive of carry; and a revised stop at -20bp, currently trading at -18.3bp.
4. Stay short USD/EGP, opened 24 April 2026, at 0%, with a revised total return target at 12% and a revised stop at 5%, currently trading at 7.4%.
5. Stay long 5y Receivers on 3m 2s5s10s Receiver Fly (bp running), opened 09 May 2026, at 1bp, with a target at 10bp and a stop at -5bp, currently trading at 0bp.
6. 1y forward 2s10s GBP OIS steepeners, opened 29 May 2026, at 0.38, with a target at 0.55 and a stop at 0.25, currently trading at 0.31.
7. Stay short THB/INR, opened 12 June 2026, at 2.91, with a target at 2.70 and a stop at 3.05, currently trading at 2.86.
8. Stay long INR 30y bonds, opened 27 June 2026, at 7.34%, with a target at 6.90% and a stop at 7.65%, currently trading at 7.40%.
9. 2s10s NZD steepeners, opened 03 July 2026, at 72bp, with a target at 90bp and a stop at 62bp, currently trading at 75bp.
10. 2s10s CAD steepeners, opened 10 July 2026, at 53bp, with a target at 80bp and a revised stop at 46bp, currently trading at 54bp.
11. Stay short AUD/NZD, via 6m 1.1650 puts, opened 14 July 2026, at 1.2000, currently trading at 1.1950.
12. Go long NIFTY Banks vs. short NIFTY Pharma, opened 15 July 2026, at 100 in local currency (INR), with a target at 115 and a stop at 90, currently trading at 103.
13. Go short GBP/USD, opened 17 July 2026, at 1.3452. with a target of 1.3250 and a

stop of 1.3600.

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